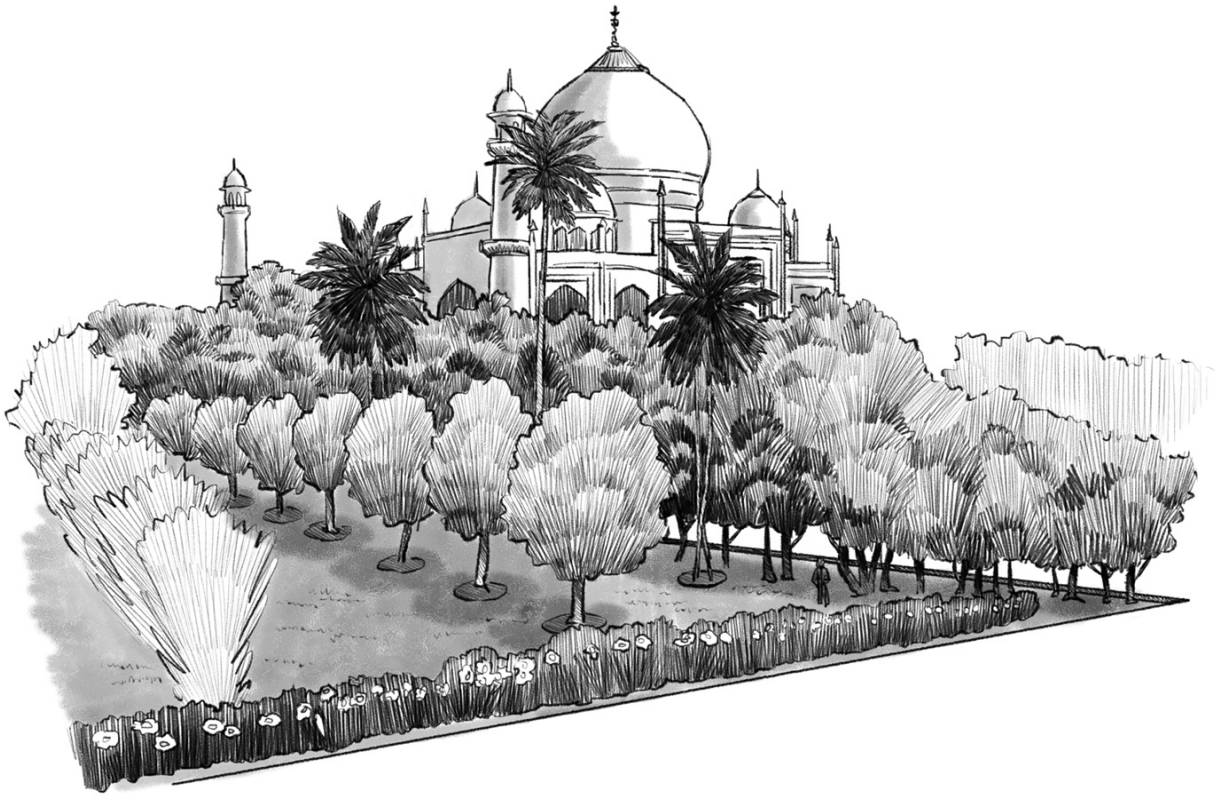
four parts by streams of water. At the center, where the streams met, was a large, square white-marble pool with fountains. This pool represented the place where the human and the divine meet. At each end of the east-west channel, platforms were built where musicians would play.

The four squares made by the streams of water were planted with trees and flowers. The trees were chosen for their shade and aroma. Fruits grew on them. Likewise, the flowers added color and scent. Birds nested in the trees, and their songs filled the air. The use of all the senses was part of the experience.



The water for the streams and fountains came from the Yamuna River. Bringing it to the complex required clever engineering. That’s because the Yamuna is lower than the ground on which the Taj Mahal was built.

First, engineers had to channel river water into a settlement tank. Here silt and other debris would sink to the bottom, purifying the water.

Then a system of thirteen *purs* brought the water up to a brick aqueduct. A pur consisted of a large roller with a rope around it. The rope was attached to a leather bucket. A pair of oxen turned the roller, pulling the bucket upward. The water inside was dumped into another tank, with